LangSci Press Review: ***Language Landscapes***

This book offers an outline of "Language Landscapes" for ESL teachers. It covers the full range of areas of descriptive linguistics, including syntax, pragmatics, the lexicon and phonetics/phonology. Semantics is not covered in a discrete chapter, but the meaning-based, broadly functional approach means that issues of semantic meaning are covered throughout the book. While the coverage is broad, the major focus is grammar, with grammatical analysis and sentence-level properties taking up the majority of chapters.

As such, the proposed book fits squarely within the aims and scope of the series, maintaining a strong linguistic focus as the jumping off point for consideration of issues of pedagogical application. The proposed book also therefore enters a relatively crowded field of works which seek to make linguistic analysis and theory (typically grammar) palatable and relevant for a language teaching audience. Some major 'competitors' which cover much of the same ground would be, but likely not limited to, the following:

- Berry, R. (2021). *Doing English grammar: Theory, description and practice*. Cambridge University Press.
- Celce-Murcia, M., & Larsen-Freeman, D. (1999). *The grammar book: an ESL/EFL teacher's course* (2. ed.). Heinle & Heinle.
- Cowan, R. (2008). *The teacher's grammar of English with answers: A course book and reference guide*. Cambridge University Press.
- Park-Johnson, S., & Shin, S. J. (2020). *Linguistics for language teachers: Lessons for classroom practice*. Routledge.
- Parrott, M. (2000). *Grammar for English Language Teachers*. Cambridge University Press.
- Valenzuela, H. (2020). *Linguistics for TESOL: Theory and practice*. Palgrave Macmillan.

The strengths of the current manuscript are that it is written in a clear and engaging style, which breaks down some complex linguistic topics in a way that makes them transparent for a non-technical audience. As such, it would be accessible and understandable for pre- or in-service teachers and might contribute to courses on TESOL. In addition, it covers areas such as fluency and conversation, which are not standardly part of similar works for TESOL/TEFL, as represented by the list above. It thus provides additional perspectives on linguistic issues which are relevant for language teaching.

There are, however, some issues with content and presentation which could detract a little from the overall potential impact and utility of the work. I outline these below for the sake of completeness and to provide potential areas for revision to the extent that revisions are possible. However, I note that many of the issues raised here are inherent to the nature of the enterprise of writing about linguistics for pedagogical purposes. As such, no single work can hope to provide definitive answers to the tricky questions at this interface, and so they should not be read as fundamental criticisms but rather as typical critiques that any and all such approaches would face one way or another.

One issue is definition of the target audience. The subtitle mentions ESL teachers. It would be useful to specify the audience a little more precisely, in particular whether it is aimed exclusively at ESL teachers. Given that ESL and EFL (and ELF, etc.) pose potentially rather different educational

challenges and certainly involve different learner populations, any suggestions for pedagogical consequences might therefore not be so easily translatable between these contexts if the target audience is really only one of them. This is not necessarily a major issue and might be addressed simply by specifying in a bit more detail who the book is for in an adapted introductory chapter. A clearer outline of the target audience and what they are expected to get from the work might also sharpen or lead to changes in some of the learning goals described for the chapters. Examples include the following, but a general review of the learning goals might be useful:

- Ch. 1 learning goal distinguish between everyday and technical meanings of grammatical terms: where does pedagogical treatment of language fall? Is it conceptualised as 'everyday' or technical? Teachers are likely to require knowledge of how to work with pedagogical grammar rather than necessarily technical work in linguistics.
- Ch. 8 learning goal Recognize common vocabulary teaching pitfalls and apply frequency-based principles: this is a very nice goal for a teaching audience, but the details of the mechanics of application in the chapter are a little thin for readers with a teaching background. "Apply" seems to relate to questions of how/when/what to teach, but these aren't addressed in the chapter.
- Ch. 14 learning goal Apply information packaging principles to improve clarity in student writing and speaking: again, a nice goal, but the mechanics of HOW to improve clarity pedagogically are missing in comparison to discussion of how linguistic patterns contribute to perceptions of clarity/information flow.

Beyond these issues of detail, and notwithstanding the welcome breadth of coverage, there is a question mark about the inclusion of some topics and their relevance to teachers. This reflects a tension between a strong linguistic focus, which is a hallmark of the textbook series, and questions of practical applicability for a TESOL/TEFL readership. Examples would be:

- Ch. 6 on phrase structure representations (and subsequent uses of syntactic trees in the remaining chapters). It is not clear why this should be useful for teachers. §6.4 "Why trees?" anticipates this issue by explaining why they could prove useful. However, it is not clear that the case for trees is successfully made. For instance, "better learning through dual encoding": better learning of what? Or, "Brevity and clarity" of explanation – but this presupposes that abstract sentence structure should be explained at all, which would be controversial in many approaches to language pedagogy. The chapter states: "By the end of this chapter, you'll have a new perspective on sentence structure - one that will enhance your understanding of English grammar and, in turn, your effectiveness as an ESL teacher." The question of pedagogical effectiveness is a huge one and whether knowing about syntax trees is a significant contributor to such efficacy seems highly questionable.
- Ch. 11, §11.2.1 Jespersen Cycle: this is inherently interesting as an analysis of language change and is illustrated nicely on the basis of negation in English. But while it contributes to an understanding of the historical development of English, it is not clear why this is useful for questions of pedagogy.

The assumption underlying the inclusion of such content seems to be that knowledge of these issues helps teachers gain a generally deeper understanding of the patterns of English and so develops their linguistic knowledge base. In this way, the book seems to aim to serve as a

corrective to concepts or descriptions which occur in "traditional" dictionaries or grammars ("traditional sources" are mentioned several times, but never precisely defined in the work. It is not clear why CGEL, on which the descriptions are based should not be viewed as "traditional"). Helping teachers navigate such information provided in teaching aids, reference works, etc. is valuable. But the discussion might have benefitted from some acknowledgement of the complexities of issues involved (see e.g. Swan, M. [2011]. Grammar. In *The Routledge handbook of applied linguistics* (pp. 557-570), and much work on pedagogical grammar and the connection between theory, description and teaching). From the perspective of a pedagogical readership, one might wonder whether the linguistic information presented will necessarily be viewed as better or clearer than "traditional" sources. For example, in Ch. 4 the presentation of adverbs and prepositions as compared to "traditional" sources. Or, in Ch. 5 the status of auxiliary verbs as the head of VP, the exact status of headedness of VP is linguistically relevant but the pedagogical importance is unclear.

On the issue of teacher knowledge. The presentation might also have been enhanced with some consideration of the nature and value of Teacher Language Awareness (e.g. Andrews, S. [2007]. *Teacher Language Awareness*. Cambridge University Press), or Teacher Knowledge about Language (e.g. Bartels, N. [2009]. Knowledge About Language. In *Cambridge Guide to Second Language Teacher Education* (pp. 125–134). Cambridge University Press.) Reference to these issues would have more successfully made the case within the work rather than leaving the assumptions implicit. Again, however, there is a practical issue of covering all bases: given the depth and breadth of linguistic coverage, it is perhaps necessary to sacrifice some pedagogical discussion. The attendant risk of this balancing act is that the transition from linguistic description to practical suggestions might appeare somewhat decontextualised. Examples of where this issue emerges in the text are as follows

- End of Ch. 3: "Teachers should be prepared for the challenge of explaining these concepts to learners clearly and simply but not simplistically." This comes after a wide-ranging discussion about analysis of categories and functions, none of which would need to be explained explicitly to learners on any standard assumptions about communicative language teaching/task-based learning/meaning-focussed input, or any number of approaches. Of course, explanation of linguistic patterns can and does play a role in language education, but simply stating this without acknowledging the complexity around it detracts from the recommendation.
- Ch. 4, p. 92 "Pause and Reflect" Box: the pedagogical implication asks about students learning about the categorical status of 'before'. It might be argued that learners don't need to know about the categorical status of 'before' at all, if they know how to use the item. As with above, this seems to presuppose an explicit approach to teaching linguistic properties. This is not an issue in itself, but it is presupposed. Spelling out the case for it somewhere would contextualise such suggestions more effectively.
- Ch. 4, §4.3.4 "Prepositions present challenges for learners": this section very effectively describes variation and history of preposition form and selection, but does not specifically relate the discussion to learnability/teachability issues such as salience, form-meaning mapping issues, and so on.
- Ch. 8, §8.6 "Pedagogical Implications": this is a nice example of how one might have separated pedagogical implications more consistently into a distinct discussion at the end of each

chapter. However, as with the examples listed above, the formulation of the pedagogical implications doesn't engage with issues of learnability/teachability in much detail.

- Ch. 9, §9.6.3 "Teaching Real Reading" is a brief summary of the "four strands" approach from Nation, which comes after extensive descriptive/analytical discussion of writing systems, spelling and historical development, but does not link very obviously to that previous linguistic discussion.

Overall, this work provides a wide-ranging and engaging introduction to a host of issues in linguistic description and analysis. The connection to questions of pedagogy sometimes remains somewhat underdeveloped for me. More engagement with models of learning/teaching would have helped to bridge between the strong focus on linguistic analysis and implications for pedagogy. Such engagement would ground the proposed applications more effectively and have bridged the linguistics-language teaching gap more clearly. However, such a gap can be approached in any number of ways, as evidenced by the list of works attempting to bridge it provided above. As such, the current work will no doubt find its audience. It is valuable for the community to have a range of perspectives and attempts at bridging the gap available. The book provides a particular perspective on issues of description and analysis and so should be available for the community as a complement to / extension of the existing works in the field.